LETTER FROM THE EDITOR-IN-CHIEF



True luxury thrives on exclusion. The moment everyone has access to something, its charm begins to evaporate. Access is the true currency of aspiration. The velvet rope, the waitlist, transforms a simple transaction into a status symbol. The watch industry turned that dictum on its head on May 16, with the release of the Audemars Piguet (AP) "Royal Pop" pocket watch. The range offers eight colourways, a bioceramic case, hand-wound movements, and goes for approximately ₹40,000 in India. Such was the unfettered enthusiasm it generated that Swatch temporarily closed around 20 stores worldwide because of safety and crowd control issues. Naturally, when a haute horology brand like AP, whose base model timepieces sell for upwards of ₹15 lakh, markets a line like the Royal Pop collection, it's bound to fuel frenzy.

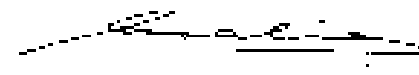
The larger question is whether the brand's legacy of carefully considered curation and mystique will survive the Saturday spectacle. The irony is that the Royal Pop is not even a limited edition. The scarce initial allocations merely created the impression of scarcity, which in modern luxury can often matter more than rarity itself.

The episode says something larger about the times we live in. Across industries, visual theatre, conceptual storytelling and carefully engineered hype are becoming central to how desirability is manufactured. Fine dining is hardly immune. In this issue's cover story, *Spice* examines the changing anatomy of culinary fame and asks whether restaurants are now competing as much for attention as for taste.



Jewellery, too, reflects the changing mood. If whisky is being defined by richness and complexity, fashion is moving towards what designers now call "maximalist minimalism": pieces that are restrained in form but deeply personal in meaning. Luxury is shifting away from seasonal display towards storytelling, individuality and conscious consumption.

Perhaps that is where modern aspiration is headed. The old rules of luxury were built on possession. The new rules may depend more on personality. In an age when almost everything can be replicated, rugged individualism may be the last real exclusivity left.



(Aroon Purie)